GRAMMAR 4: PARALLELISM

Parallelism, or parallel structure, is an important feature in English writing. It means that when you are listing a series of ideas, or comparing/contrasting ideas, each item in your list must have the same grammatical structure. For example, if you are writing a list and the first item in your list is a verb, all the other items in your list must also be verbs. If the first item is a noun, the other items must also be nouns.

Study the following sentences. Note the parallel structures in each sentence.

- I like to swim, to surf, and to waterski. (infinitive/uninflected verbs)
- While he was thinking about the class lectures and reviewing some articles, he formulated an idea for his paper. (present participles)
- Nowadays, computers are used heavily by many people and in many different ways. (prepositional phrases)
- Professor Lim has promised that the term papers will be marked by 6 pm and that all the scores will be posted outside his office by tomorrow morning. (noun clauses)
- The teacher is friendly and helpful, but somewhat disorganised. (adjectives)

Signal Words/Phrases for Parallel Structures

Coordinating Conjunctions

Words, phrases and clauses that are joined by coordinating conjunctions – **AND, OR, BU**T – are written in parallel structure. For example:

1) Helicopters have the ability to take off vertically **and** to land on a small surface area.
2) Pesticides cannot be sold if they have a harmful effect on humans, animal life, **or** the environment.
3) The law regulates the noise created by motor vehicles **but** not by commercial aircraft.

Paired Conjunctions

Words, phrases and clauses that are joined by paired conjunctions – **BOTH… AND…; EITHER… OR…; NEITHER… NOR…; NOT ONLY… BUT ALSO…** – are written in parallel structure. For example:

1) A new law provides for **both** regulating pesticides **and** ordering their removal if they are dangerous.
2) Air pollutants may come **either** from the ocean as natural contaminants emitted by sea life **or** from internal combustion of automobile engines.
3) If **neither** industry **nor** the public works toward reducing pollution problems, future generations will suffer.
4) Presently, air pollution is controlled through laws passed **not only** to reduce the pollutants at their sources **but also** to set up acceptable standards of air quality.

Exercise 1: Identifying parallel elements

Two or more items in the following sentences are written in a parallel structure. Underline the items or ideas that are parallel and circle the word or words that connect them. The first one has been done for you.

1) An ideal environment for studying includes good lighting, a spacious desk, and a comfortable chair.
2) You know you are truly fluent in another language when you can calculate in it and when you begin to dream in it.
3) People often spend as much time worrying about the future as planning for it.
4) My new laptop is both fast and reliable.
5) The criminal neither admitted guilt nor asked for forgiveness before he was sent to jail.
6) You can learn a second language in the classroom, at home, or in a country where the language is spoken.
7) The students can submit their papers either today or next Monday.
8) Both my brother and his friend obtained their degrees from the National University of Singapore.
9) My English class is made up of students from China, Spain, and Iran.
10) She wanted to come to the party, but she couldn't leave her mother alone at home.

Exercise 2: Correcting faulty parallelism

Underline the part of the sentence that is not parallel to the similar items and write a correction on the lines below. The first one has been done for you as an example.

1) The disadvantages of using a credit card are overspending and you pay high interest rates.

   The disadvantages of using a credit card are overspending and paying high interest rates.

2) Credit cards are accepted by department stores, airlines, and they can be used in some hospitals.

   _____

   _____

3) You do not need to risk carrying cash or to risk to miss a sale.

   _____

   _____

4) With credit cards, you can either pay your bill with one check or stretching out your payments.

   _____

   _____

5) You can charge both at restaurants and when you stay at hotels.

_____

_____

6) Many people carry not only credit cards but they also carry cash.

_____

_____

7) Many people want neither to pay off their balance every month nor do they like paying interest.

_____

_____

8) Not making any payment or to send in only the minimum payment every month is poor money management.

_____

_____

9) The teacher wants to know which country we come from and our future goals.

_____

_____

10) The students who get high marks attend class regularly, they do their homework, and practice speaking in English.

_____

_____

Exercise 3: Correcting faulty parallelism

Rewrite the following sentences by making all similar elements parallel.

1) Swimming in the lake and to walk through the woods are his favorite pastimes.

_____

_____

2) Mary is tall with blond hair, and who has blue eyes.

_____

3) The head of the department must have experience, education, and he or she must be creative.

_____

_____

4) It was his personality, not that he was talented, that helped him advance professionally.

_____

_____

5) Knowing how to study and to be able to budget time are important for university students.

_____

_____

6) Come to the meeting prepared to take notes and with some questions to ask.

_____

_____

7) The vice-president walked off smiling at the audience and with a bow to the retiring employees.

_____

_____

8) The ambassador from Britain spoke with warmth and in a humorous way.

_____

9) We found the directory useful not only to locate information but also for providing a list of names.

_____

_____

10) Take these precautions:
- No contact lenses or glasses should be worn
- Solutions should not touch clothes.
- Keep away from children.

_____

_____

_____

Exercise 4: Creating parallel elements

Complete the following sentences in your own words. Make sure you use parallel structure.

1) Three things I enjoy doing in my free time are

_____

_____

_____

2) In my opinion, a good teacher has the following characteristics:

_____

_____

_____

3) Several good places to go for a bicycle ride in (or near) the city I live in are

_____

_____

_____

Adapted from:

Lane, J. & Lange, E. (1999). *Writing clearly: An editing guide (2nd ed.)*. Boston: Heinle & Heinle.
Oshima, A. & Hogue, A. (2006). *Writing academic English (4th ed.)*. White Plains, NY: Pearson Longman.